MOBILE PHONE THEFT ON THE RISE IN HAWASSA AS THIEVES CHANGE TACTICS

By Nejat Muhammad — April 3, 2026

Mobile phone theft is becoming an increasing concern in Hawassa City, as criminals adopt new and more sophisticated methods to carry out their activities. Incidents range from pickpocketing and dormitory break-ins to phone snatching by thieves using motorbikes.

According to Vice Inspector Yrdachew Angiso from the Hawassa City Police Criminal Investigation Department, the city records an average of two to three phone theft cases each week. He noted that many suspects are young individuals, often from rural areas or living on the streets, who are influenced by peer pressure or driven by the desire to earn quick money.

> "Some offenders operate in organized groups and frequently change their tactics, which makes them difficult to identify and arrest," he explained.

In recent years, the number of mobile phone users in Hawassa has increased significantly, especially among students and young people. As smartphones become more valuable and widely used for communication, education, and financial services, they have also become attractive targets for theft.

Many of these crimes take place during the evening or late at night when people are less alert. Victims report that phones are commonly stolen while they are asleep, walking alone, or using public transportation. In some cases, thieves carefully observe their targets before taking action.

Kena Deresa, a university student, shared her experience of losing her phone while sleeping in her dormitory. "Someone quietly entered our room at night and took my phone while it was

charging. I didn't wake up until my roommate shouted," she said. Although the incident was reported to the police, her phone has not yet been recovered.

Another student, Etsubdink Abraham, described a case in which her friend's phone was snatched by two men on a motorbike while returning to campus. "Since then, I avoid walking while holding my phone in my hand," she said, explaining how the incident changed their daily behavior.

Phone theft is also common in crowded public areas and on public transportation. Ethiopia Kebede, a Hawassa resident, said her phone went missing while she was visiting a friend near Piassa. "I was in a busy place, but somehow my phone disappeared. I only realized it a few minutes later," she explained.

The increasing number of theft cases is not only causing financial loss but also creating fear among residents. Many people now feel unsafe using their phones in public places or even inside their dormitories. Students, in particular, are becoming more cautious in their daily movements.

In response to the rising incidents, the police are working closely with the community through the Community Policing Program to prevent such crimes. Both uniformed and plainclothes officers have been deployed in different parts of the city to improve security and respond quickly to reported cases.

Police advise residents to remain vigilant, especially in crowded or isolated areas, and to avoid displaying their phones openly in public. They also recommend keeping doors locked at night, securing personal belongings, and reporting suspicious activities immediately.

As mobile phone theft continues to rise, both law enforcement and the community must work together to improve safety. Raising public awareness and taking preventive measures are essential steps toward reducing such crimes and ensuring a safer environment for everyone in Hawassa.